

Back from the break, and straight into a fight

4 divisions 2,247 written questions 236 distinct askers

For the first half of the week the Commons was dark. Members of Parliament were still on their Whitsun holidays until Sunday. They filed back in on Monday and got straight to work. There were four votes on the Armed Forces Bill. A 'votes at 16' bill and a duty-of-candour bill both reached report stage. And 236 Members of Parliament lodged 2,247 written questions on everything from Ebola in the Congo to NHS dentistry. Health, as ever, drew the most fire.

THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST

Armed Forces Bill, New Clause 2

171 302

Not carried by 131 on 2 June

Armed Forces Bill, New Clause 5

170 301

Not carried by 131 on 2 June

Armed Forces Bill, New Clause 13

80 298

Not carried by 218 on 2 June

Armed Forces Bill, New Clause 6

99 371

Not carried by 272 on 2 June

WRITTEN QUESTIONS, BY DEPARTMENT

Health	282
Defence	216
Cabinet Office	177
Transport	163
Treasury	152
Education	150
Home Office	147
Housing	138
Environment	129
Ministry of Justice	116
Work and Pensions	109
Business and Trade	107
14 others	361

THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS

- 12 Democratic Republic of the Congo: Ebola 12 Pupils: Asthma 11 NHS: Databases 11 Political Parties: Finance
 11 Military Aircraft: Training 11 Multinational Companies: Taxation 10 Animal Experiments
 10 Peacekeeping Operations: Strait of Hormuz 10 Civil Servants: Workplace Pensions 8 Unemployment: Young People

A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK'S QUESTIONS

Dental Services: Contracts · Andrew Snowden, Conservative

Has the Department assessed the impact of variation in Unit of Dental Activity (UDA) values between NHS dental contracts within the same Integrated Care Board area?

THE ANSWER From 1 April 2023, commissioning responsibility for primary care dentistry transferred to integrated care boards, including the duty to assess local oral health needs and set commissioning priorities. NHS England has issued an Assurance Framework to support boards in doing so.

General Practitioners: Contracts · Dr Roz Savage, Liberal Democrat

What assessment has been made of the patient-safety implications of mandating 'Advice and Guidance' as a required step in GP referral pathways under the 2026/27 GP contract?

THE ANSWER The contract does not change the clinical threshold for referral to specialist care. GPs should continue to make a clinical decision to refer for specialist care where that is in the patient's best interests, and to request specialist advice where appropriate.

Shipping: UK Emissions Trading Scheme

· Joe Robertson, Conservative

What criteria does the Department use to define the 'unique challenges' faced by Scottish island communities under the shipping Emissions Trading Scheme?

THE ANSWER There are over 90 inhabited island and peninsula communities in Scotland that rely on ferry services, each with distinct geographic contexts and with populations ranging from fewer than 10 to just over 21,000 inhabitants.

FEATURE

The police handling of the Henry Nowak stabbing

The most-pressed single subject of the week never appeared under any official heading. Rupert Lowe (Restore Britain) tabled eight written questions to the Home Office over the police response to the fatal stabbing of Henry Nowak. He pressed on whether attending officers misidentified the dying victim as a suspect, why he was handcuffed while seriously injured, and whether first-aid and casualty-care protocols were followed.